GRIT OS

Student-Athlete
Coach Communication Guide

*How to Communicate with College Coaches — Professionally, Confidently, and Strategically – **if they contact you first***

Introduction: The Recruiting Relationship

Every message you receive from a college coach is an opportunity. How you respond communicates far more than just your words — it signals your character, your seriousness, your maturity, and your fit for their program.

This guide gives you word-for-word language, strategic context, and insider knowledge to help you navigate every stage of the recruiting process with poise. Read it, practice it, and keep it handy.

The Five Pillars of Great Coach Communication

- Be Positive — coaches recruit attitude as much as athleticism.
- Be Respectful — understand their process and timeline; never pressure.
- Be Engaged — show genuine interest and ask thoughtful questions.
- Be Professional — clear, concise, and free of slang.
- Be Timely — respond within 24–48 hours whenever possible.

⚠️ Always Check First

Before scheduling any campus visit or camp: Check with your parents.

Before sharing academic records or grades: Check with your guidance counselor.

Before making any financial commitment: Check with your parents.

When in doubt about any next step: Ask Coach Conroy

Section 1: Your First Communication from a Coach

What Legitimate Recruiting Contact Looks Like

When a college coach first reaches out, it can arrive by email, text message, or social media DM (especially on X/Twitter). Before you respond, verify that the contact is legitimate.

Email: Signs It's Real

- Comes from an official .edu address (e.g., coach@college.edu), not Gmail, Outlook, or Yahoo.
- References your specific athletic achievements, your film, or your high school by name.
- Includes the coach's name and title.
- Does NOT ask for money, gift cards, or personal financial information.

Text Message: Signs It's Real

- The coach identifies themselves by name, title, and school in the first message.

- You can sometimes verify the number via a quick internet search or the school's athletic directory.
- Some coaches forget to give their name when they text you for the first time. *(If this is the case and you get a text from them out of the blue, just say, **"Hey Coach! Thanks for the message. What's your full name and email so I can save them in my phone? I don't want to forget."**)* If a coach texts you but won't give you a legitimate email, it is likely a scam.
- NCAA rules restrict when coaches can text you, depending on your grade year — unusual early contact may indicate the coach is testing waters, but it could also be a phishing scam that is impersonating the coach. Always get the coach's email as well as their number.

X/Twitter DM: Signs It's Real

- The account has a verified badge or a consistent history of posts tied to the program.
- The handle matches or closely resembles the coach's name or the school's branding.
- Always cross-reference by visiting the school's official athletics website.

🔍 Quick Verification Checklist

1. Google: [Coach Name] + [School Name] + Football — does the result match?
2. Go to the school's official athletics website and find the coaching staff page.
3. If the contact came via email, check that the domain matches the school's .edu address.
4. If something feels off, tell a parent, coach, or counselor before responding.

Your First Response: General Template

Once you have confirmed the contact is legitimate, here is a strong first response:

✅ Ideal First Response (Email or Text)

"Coach [Last Name], thank you for reaching out — I am honored to hear from [School Name].

I have a lot of respect for your program and what you have built there.

I would love to learn more about the opportunity. Please let me know what next steps

you would like me to take. I look forward to the conversation.

Best, [Your Name] | [Position] | [High School] | [Graduation Year]"

💡 Keep in Mind

Keep your first response short, warm, and action-ready.

Never express desperation or over-excitement — show measured enthusiasm.

Always include your name, position, school, and grad year in your signature.

If contacted via DM, it is acceptable to ask the coach for their email to continue the conversation more formally.

Section 2: Common Recruiting Scenarios & Ideal Responses

Each scenario below includes what a coach might say and the ideal way for you to respond. These templates are starting points — personalize them with real details about yourself and the program.

Scenario 1: A Coach Asks If You Filled Out Their Recruiting Questionnaire

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"Hey [Name], just wanted to check — did you get a chance to fill out our recruiting questionnaire?

It really helps us get the process started on our end."

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Coach [Last Name], thank you for following up! I have filled it out / I will complete it

today. I want to make sure you have everything you need. Is there anything else

I can send over to help with your evaluation? I am excited about the possibility

of being part of your program. — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

Fill out every recruiting questionnaire within 24 hours of receiving a coach's contact.

Questionnaires are the first formal step — coaches use them to track interested prospects.

Be thorough and accurate. Do not exaggerate stats or GPA. Be sure to add your film and transcript if you have them.

If you haven't filled one out yet, do it immediately before responding.

Scenario 2: A Coach Requests Your Transcript

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"We are very interested in you as a prospect. Can you send us a copy of your

transcript so our admissions team can take a look?"

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Coach [Last Name], absolutely — I appreciate your interest and want to get you

what you need. I will check with my guidance counselor today and have an official

transcript sent over as quickly as possible. Should I send it directly to you,

or is there a specific admissions contact I should use? — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

ALWAYS check with your guidance counselor before sharing academic records.

Most schools require an official transcript sent directly from your school — not an emailed photo.

Knowing your GPA and course rigor (AP, Honors, IB) helps coaches assess academic fit. Be prepared.

Never misrepresent your academic record. Coaches and admissions offices will verify everything.

Scenario 3: A Coach Invites You to a Junior Day or Official Visit

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"We would love to have you on campus for our Junior Day on [Date]. It is a great chance

to see the facilities, meet the staff, and get a feel for our program. Can you make it?"

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Coach [Last Name], thank you so much for the invitation — I am very interested

in seeing the program up close. I need to check the date with my parents and

confirm our schedule, but I will follow up with you by [specific date, e.g., end of

the week]. I am genuinely excited about the opportunity. — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

Never commit to a visit without checking with your parents first — visits may involve travel costs, logistics, and time off from school.
Junior Days are unofficial — the school cannot pay for your travel at this stage.
Official Visits (5 max in FBS/FCS) are paid by the school and are a strong sign of serious interest.
After confirming with your parents, respond promptly with a definite yes or a respectful decline.
If declining, always thank the coach and leave the door open for future contact.

Scenario 4: A Coach Asks You to Attend Their Camp

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"We run a prospect camp this summer and I think it would be a great opportunity for

you to come work out for our staff. I really think you could make a strong impression."

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Coach [Last Name], thank you for the invitation — I take it as a real compliment.

I would love the opportunity to compete in front of your staff.

I will discuss the details with my parents and get back to you shortly.

Could you send me the camp information so we can review it together? — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

Camp invitations are often a coach's way of evaluating a prospect in person without using an official visit.
Camps typically cost money — check with parents before committing.
Performing well at a coach's own camp carries significant weight in their evaluation.
Note: if multiple schools invite you to their camps on similar dates, prioritize based on your interest level and talk it through with your family.

Scenario 5: A Coach Asks What Other Schools Are Recruiting You

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"We want to understand your recruiting landscape. What other programs have shown

interest in you so far?"

Your answer here is strategic. Use the context of WHO is asking to send appropriate market signals.

✅ If asked by an FCS / Patriot League / CAA Coach

"I have received interest from several programs at the FCS level, including schools in the Patriot League and CAA. I have also had outreach from a few high academic Division III programs. I am keeping my options open right now and focusing on finding the best fit athletically and academically. [School Name] is definitely high on my list — I respect what you have built here. — [Your Name]"

✅ If asked by a High Academic D3 Coach (e.g., NESCAC, UAA)

"I have received interest from programs at the FCS level in conferences like the Patriot League and CAA. I am genuinely weighing both opportunities because I care deeply about academic quality. The academic profile of [School Name] is very compelling to me, and I am taking your program very seriously. — [Your Name]"

💡 Strategic Notes on This Question

- Being honest about FCS interest signals your competitive value to D3 coaches — it increases your leverage.
- Do NOT name specific schools if you are not certain of their interest — coaches talk to each other.
- Expressing that their school is 'high on your list' is appropriate as long as it is true.
- Never fabricate offers or interest you do not have. It will come back to hurt you.
- You are not obligated to share every school — you can say 'a handful of programs at the FCS level.'

Scenario 6: A Coach Asks If You Play Another Sport

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"Are you a multi-sport athlete? Do you participate in any other sports during the year?"

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Yes, Coach — I also compete in track and field, specifically in the high jump.

It has been a great complement to football — it has sharpened my explosiveness, body control, and competitiveness. I am genuinely interested in participating in track at the college level as well. I wanted to be transparent with you about that early in the process. — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

- Be upfront about your track aspirations early — coaches appreciate honesty and it avoids complications later.
- Multi-sport athletes are viewed positively. Track training complements football athleticism.
- Ask each football coach how their program typically handles multi-sport athletes — it shows maturity.
- Some programs actively encourage it; others may have scheduling conflicts. Better to know early.

Scenario 7: A Coach Asks What Position You Prefer to Play

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"We have you flagged as a defensive back / wide receiver. What position do you see yourself playing at the next level?"

✅ Your Ideal Response

"Coach, I play both cornerback and wide receiver right now, and I genuinely enjoy both positions. That said, I had my best year on the defensive side of the ball and was named All-Conference as a cornerback during my junior year, which I am really proud of. I see myself as a cornerback at the next level, but I want to be coachable and flexible — I trust your staff's evaluation. — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

- Lead with your strongest credential: All-Conference honors at CB.
- Expressing flexibility is smart — coaches value players who put the team first.
- If a coach is recruiting you at a position you do not prefer, ask respectful questions about the depth chart.
- Never shut the door on a position outright during early recruiting conversations.

Scenario 8: A Coach Asks What You Plan to Study

📣 What the Coach Might Say

"What are you thinking about studying in college? Do you have an academic interest area?"

✅ Your Ideal Response

"I am most interested in Business Administration — I am interested in areas like strategy,

finance, and entrepreneurship. I know not every school has a dedicated Business

program by that exact name, so I have also been exploring programs in Economics,

Management and related fields that lead to similar career paths. What does

[School Name] offer in that space? — [Your Name]"

💡 Keep in Mind

- This answer does two things: it shows academic seriousness, AND it invites the coach to sell their academics.
- Researching each school's specific offerings before your conversation is very impressive to coaches.
- For schools without a Business major, look for: Economics, Management, Finance, or Organizational Studies.
- Never express academic disinterest — academic fit is a real part of the evaluation, especially at FCS and D3 levels.
- Confirm your actual academic information with your guidance counselor before sharing specifics.

Section 3: The Coach Translator

College coaches communicate in a recruiting dialect that can be confusing or misleading if you take everything at face value. This section decodes the most common phrases so you always know what is really being said — and how to respond intelligently.

When a Coach Says...	It Usually Means...	Consider & Communicate...
"We are very interested in you."	We like your film but have not made a decision. You are in our evaluation pool.	Thank them, express mutual interest, ask what information they need from you to move forward.

When a Coach Says...	It Usually Means...	Consider & Communicate...
"We are keeping a close eye on you."	We know you exist but are not ready to commit any resources yet. Watch-and-wait status.	Keep performing on the field and stay in touch. Update them after strong performances.
"You need to come to our camp to be evaluated."	We want to see you in person before making any recruiting decisions. You are not yet offered.	Treat the camp as an important audition. Discuss logistics and cost with parents before committing.
"We are still early in our evaluation."	You are not a top priority right now, but they are not closing the door either.	Stay engaged, keep sending updates, and do not take yourself off the market waiting for them.
"We have you high on our board."	You are among their top targets at your position — this is encouraging but not an offer.	Express genuine excitement. Ask what the next step in their process looks like for you.
"We want to offer you."	This is an official scholarship or walk-on offer. This is the real thing.	Thank them sincerely. Ask for the offer details in writing. Discuss with parents before responding.
"We need a decision by [date]."	The offer has an expiration. They are managing their roster. This is real pressure.	Discuss immediately with parents and weigh against your other options. Do not be rushed into a bad fit — but respect their timeline.
"You are our top guy at your position."	You are their #1 target at CB/WR — this is a strong signal. But coaches can have multiple "top guys."	Appreciate the compliment, express the program is a priority for you too. Ask about the offer timeline.
"We need to see your grades."	Academic eligibility or admissions fit is a real question they need answered.	Tell them you will connect with your guidance counselor and get them what they need promptly.
"Our coaching staff loves your film."	Multiple coaches have watched you — this is a meaningful positive signal.	Express gratitude and ask which coaches reviewed it. This helps you understand staff investment.
"We will be at your game on Friday."	An in-person evaluation — one of the most significant steps in the process.	Let your high school coach know. Play your game. Do not try to do too much to impress — trust your talent.
"Stay in touch with us."	They are interested but not ready to commit. They want YOU to keep the relationship warm.	Send them brief updates after key performances, awards, or new film. Every 2–3 weeks is appropriate.
"We are going in a different direction."	You are no longer being actively recruited by this program. This is a respectful rejection.	Thank them for their time. Ask if they know of other programs that might be a good fit. Stay professional.
"We have limited spots in this class."	There is real urgency — they are managing a finite roster and timeline.	Take the signal seriously. If you are genuinely interested, say so clearly. If not, be honest and respectful.

When a Coach Says...	It Usually Means...	Consider & Communicate...
"What other schools are you talking to?"	They want to gauge your market value and seriousness. A competitive-intelligence question.	Be honest at the category level (FCS conferences, High Academic D3) and only name specific schools unless you are confident of their interest. Affirm that their program is high on your list if it is true.
"What other schools are you looking at?"	A softer version — they are gauging your decision timeline and how they stack up against your options.	Share your general search criteria (academic profile, conference level, geography) and affirm genuine interest in their program. Name other schools you are in serious discussions with. Frame it as a thoughtful search, not a passive one.
"Send us your tape." (early / pre-questionnaire)	They saw a stat line, a referral, or a social post and are doing low-cost triage before a formal relationship exists.	Complete their questionnaire FIRST. Then respond: 'I filled out your questionnaire today so you have my full profile — here is my film link. What cut-ups would be most useful for your staff?' This signals process maturity.
"Send us your game tape." (late / pre-senior year)	This signals that coaches are likely not interested in you as a recruit.	You can send the coach your pre-season and first two game highlights, but do not expect to be actively recruited by this school.

Section 4: Quick Reference Checklist

Before Every Response to a Coach

- Is this contact coming from a verified, legitimate source?
- Am I responding within 24-48 hours?
- Is my language professional, positive, and free of slang?
- If scheduling a visit or camp — have I checked with my parents?
- If sharing academic information — have I checked with my guidance counselor?

Your Standard Email Signature

📋 Use This Every Time

[Your Full Name]

[Position: Cornerback / Wide Receiver]

[High School Name] | Class of [Year] | Cumulative GPA

[Height / Weight / 40-Yard Dash if available]

[Recruiting Profile Link — e.g., Hudl, NCSA, 247Sports]

[Phone Number]

NCAA Recruiting Calendar D1-FCS & D3: Key Rules to Know

The recruiting calendar governs when coaches can contact you, evaluate you, and extend offers. Understanding it helps you read a coach's behavior, manage your own timeline, and make smarter decisions. The calendar below is organized by grade year and season — read it from top to bottom as your career unfolds.

When	Milestone / Rule	What It Means for You
BEFORE JUNIOR YEAR — Building Your Foundation (Context)		
Anytime (pre-Jr.)	**Questionnaires & Camp Brochures Only**	FCS coaches may send questionnaires and camp brochures to any age. Fill out every questionnaire immediately — it starts the formal relationship. No phone calls or texts permitted yet.
Anytime (pre-Jr.)	**No Phone / Text / In-Person Contact (FCS)**	FCS coaches cannot call, text, or meet you off-campus before Sept. 1 of your junior year. If a coach is contacting you by phone before that date, verify it carefully — or ask a trusted adult.
Sept. 1, Jr. Year	🟢 **CONTACT OPENS — Verbal Offers Begin**	FCS coaches may now call, text, email, and extend verbal scholarship offers. A verbal offer is NOT binding — neither side is locked in. But this is when the real conversations start. Be ready, be professional, be positive.
AUG 1 – AUG 31, 2025 (Pre-Season / Start of Senior Year)		
Aug. 1–31, 2025	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD (most of August)**	No in-person recruiting contact on or off campus. No official or unofficial visits. Coaches can still call, text, and email. Do not expect campus visits this month.
48 hrs before/after home game (Aug. / Sept. 1–2)	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD window**	For home games that fall in August or Sept. 1–2, a 48-hour quiet window opens before and after the game. On-campus contact only during this window — no off-campus evaluations.
SEPT 1 – NOV 30, 2025 — Fall Evaluation Period (Senior Year Games)		
Sept. 1 – Nov. 30	🔵 **EVALUATION PERIOD (33 days)**	Coaches may attend your games and evaluate you in person off-campus — but they CANNOT approach you or have an in-person recruiting conversation off-campus during this time. A coach in the stands = serious interest. Play your game.
Sept. 1 – Nov. 30	📋 **Senior Year Evaluation = High Interest Signal**	Coaches using precious evaluation days to watch you in person during senior year are strongly considering you. After the game, send them a quick text: 'Coach, great seeing you there — I hope you liked what you saw. Looking forward to talking soon.'
Oct. 15 (approx.)	📌 **Early Decision (ED) Application Deadline**	Many Patriot League, CAA, and High Academic D3 schools have ED deadlines around Oct. 15. If a coach is advocating for you with admissions, applying ED signals commitment

When	Milestone / Rule	What It Means for You
		and strengthens their ability to support you. Discuss with coach AND guidance counselor first.
Nov. 1 (approx.)	📌 **Early Action / Restrictive EA Deadlines**	Non-binding early application deadlines. EA lets you apply to multiple schools early. REA (e.g., Harvard, Stanford) limits you to one private school. Coaches at academic schools often want you to apply early so admissions can clear you before signing day.
DEC 1 – DEC 21, 2025 — Early Signing Period & Contact Window		
Dec. 1–4	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD**	Four-day dead period immediately following the fall evaluation window. No in-person contact on or off campus. No visits. Phone and written contact continues.
Dec. 5–18	🟢 **CONTACT PERIOD (2 weeks)**	Full off-campus contact and evaluation allowed. Coaches can visit your school, meet with you off-campus, and host official visits. This is the most active window before Early Signing Day. Official visit offers during this window are very serious.
~Dec. 17 (Wed.)	✍️ **EARLY NATIONAL SIGNING DAY — Early Cycle**	The first NLI signing day (typically the third Wednesday of December). Early-cycle recruits who verbally committed in Oct.–Nov. sign here. Signing makes your commitment official and binding. You become an Early Cycle recruit. Academic school ED decisions often align with this window.
Dec. 19–21	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD (3 days)**	On-campus contact only. No off-campus recruiting. A brief wind-down before the holiday dead period.
DEC 22, 2025 – JAN 4, 2026 — Holiday Dead Period		
Dec. 22 – Jan. 4	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD (Holiday)**	No in-person recruiting contact or visits — on or off campus — for all prospects except midyear transfer enrollees. The recruiting world goes quiet. Use this time to reflect, discuss with family, and prepare your questions for coaches when contact resumes.
Dec. 31 – Jan. 4	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD (Transfer prospects only)**	A quiet period carve-out for two- and four-year college transfer prospects who plan to enroll midyear. Standard high school prospects remain in the dead period.
Nov. 15 – Jan. 1 (approx.)	📌 **Regular Decision Application Deadlines**	Most college RD deadlines fall in this window. If you have not signed early, coordinate with your coach about when admissions decisions come back and how that timing affects your signing day plan.
JAN 5 – JAN 31, 2026 — January Contact Period & Late Cycle Begins		
Jan. 5–31 (most days)	🟢 **CONTACT PERIOD**	Full off-campus contact resumes. Coaches can visit your school, attend events, and host official visits. Late-cycle recruits still uncommitted are actively being recruited. If you are unsigned, now is the time to visit your top schools and ask for clarity on offers.
Jan. 11	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD (1 day)**	One-day quiet period. On-campus contact only. No off-campus evaluations this day.
Jan. 12–14	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD (3 days)**	No in-person recruiting contact or visits on or off campus.
FEB 1, 2026 — Late National Signing Day		

When	Milestone / Rule	What It Means for You
Feb. 1	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD (Signing Day)**	Feb. 1 is a quiet period — on-campus contact only. This is Late National Signing Day. Regular-cycle recruits who committed in December–January sign here. This is still a major signing day with significant NLI activity.
~Feb. 1 (Wed.)	✍️ **LATE NATIONAL SIGNING DAY — Regular Cycle**	Traditional NLI signing day. Regular-cycle recruits sign here. Some late-cycle prospects are still deciding. If you are unsigned on Feb. 1, you are a late-cycle recruit — schools with open spots are still actively recruiting you.
FEB 2 – APR 14, 2026 — Post-Signing Dead & Quiet Periods		
Feb. 2 – Mar. 1	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD**	Four weeks of no in-person contact. No visits. This follows the signing day rush. Phone and written communication continues. If you are still unsigned, stay in contact with coaches by phone and email.
Mar. 2 – Apr. 14	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD**	On-campus contact only for six weeks. Coaches can host you for unofficial visits on campus. No off-campus evaluations. **A good window to take self-funded campus visits to schools still pursuing you.**
Late Feb. – Mar.	📌 **FBS Transfer Portal Winter Window Closes**	**Invitations to Junior Days and visits are here.** FBS players who entered the portal after bowl season make their decisions. As FBS portal activity settles, FCS coaches know their full roster picture — some new spots open, some offers shift. Late-cycle FCS prospects may benefit from this movement.
APR 15 – MAY 23, 2026 — Spring Contact Period		
Apr. 15 – May 23	🟢 **CONTACT PERIOD (140 recruiting-person days)**	Full off-campus contact and evaluation resumes. Coaches can visit your school, attend spring practices, and host official visits. Late-cycle recruits still available get significant attention here. This is the last major contact window of the recruiting year.
Apr. 15 – May 23	📌 **Late Cycle Recruits: Final Window**	If you are still unsigned entering this contact period, this is your last best window to visit, receive offers, and commit before the summer dead period. Schools with unresolved roster needs are actively recruiting. Be proactive — reach out to coaches directly.
MAY 24 – JUL 31, 2026 — End of Recruiting Year		
May 24–27	🔴 **DEAD PERIOD (4 days)**	Short dead period as the spring contact window closes. No in-person contact or visits.
May 28 – Jul. 31	🟡 **QUIET PERIOD (Summer)**	**On-campus contact only through the end of the recruiting year (July 31). Coaches can host camps** — attending a school's summer camp during this period is one of the few ways to be evaluated in person. This marks the end of the 2025–26 recruiting cycle.
Summer (June–July)	🏕️ **Summer Camps — Key Evaluation Opportunity**	Even during the quiet period, camps held on campus are permitted. Attending a school's summer camp is one of the best ways to be seen in person and earn an offer late. Discuss costs and logistics with parents before committing to any camp.

📌 Recruiting Cycle Quick Reference (FCS 2025–26)

Early Cycle: Commit Oct.–Nov. → sign Early NSD (~Dec. 17, 2025, third Wednesday of December).

Regular Cycle: Commit Dec.–Jan. → sign Late NSD (Feb. 1, 2026).

Late Cycle: Still unsigned after Feb. 1 → spring contact period (Apr. 15–May 23) is your last major window.

Verbal Commitment: NOT binding. Either side may back out. The NLI (signed on NSD) is the only binding document.

Official Visit Limit: 5 total across all schools. Use them only on your most serious options.

Period Types: 🔴 Dead = no contact on/off campus | 🟡 Quiet = on-campus only | 🔵 Evaluation = coaches watch, no contact | 🟢 Contact = full access.

Academic Deadlines run parallel:

- ED (~Oct. 15)
- EA/REA (~Nov. 1)
- RD (~Jan. 1) — coordinate with Coach Conroy, your HS coach, your parents, and your counselor

⚠️ Final Reminders

Your character speaks before you arrive on campus — coaches evaluate how you communicate.

Respond to every coach, even to decline. The recruiting world is small.

Never burn a bridge. The coach who recruits you may move to another school someday.

Stay humble, stay grateful, and stay focused on performing at the highest level.

The right fit is where you will thrive athletically, academically, and personally.

GritOS — Helping Student-Athletes Find Their Platinum Opportunity